

Looks like fitness could become fun after all!

Much more to explore

We saw several more applications of the metaverse in the course of our series so far, ranging from art and entertainment to socialising and marketing.

Socialising. When Facebook changed the company name to Meta, the messaging was clear that the metaverse is the future of socialising. People would no longer be connecting over text chats or even voice or video calls. Instead, they will escape to their favourite virtual hangout in some world in the metaverse, and chill by playing their favourite games or just chatting, as if everyone is sitting together in the same room!

Entertainment. The entertainment industry is also making its presence felt in the metaverse, what with Indian artists like Daler Mehndi and south Indian playback singer Karthik performing in the metaverse. When movies start releasing in the metaverse, it will be a totally transformative experience capable of shaking up the whole industry, because sitting in the living room with a VR headset on, a person can experience the same magic as in a large format theatre with surround sound. The homemade popcorn and coffee would also work out cheaper than in a theatre.

Art. The art industry is benefiting greatly by the metaverse. Digital artists are able to sell their work on the metaverse as NFTs, while art galleries are using the blockchain to certify the authenticity of rare and high-value works of art. Sotheby's has even opened a store in the metaverse to showcase and auction rare NFTs. Several art galleries auctioned salvaged digital versions of artworks lost in the Ukrainian war to support the artists.

Marketing. Celebrities, brands, sports associations, almost everyone

is using the metaverse to market themselves or their wares. Sports clubs are selling trading cards and historic moments as NFTs. Fashion brands are selling NFTs of upcoming products to create awareness and check the market response. From toilet paper to pizzas, brands are floating themed NFTs to connect with the next generation of consumers who are spending significant time in the metaverse!

To spend or not to spend

All said and done, there is always the dilemma that any company faces—whether to invest in the metaverse or not. Privacy and cost are two of the major concerns discouraging companies hoping to foray into this new world.

Privacy. Experts are worried about privacy and safety in the metaverse. While a digital twin, be it of an organisation or a person, is highly beneficial in many respects, it is also a privacy nightmare, because it is, after all, a twin, and carries with it a wealth of personal information.

A survey of 1000+ adults in the US conducted in December 2021 by Propeller Insights for NordVPN showed that 55% of those surveyed did not really know what the metaverse is. 87% were concerned about how the metaverse could affect their privacy. “They think it might be easy for hackers to impersonate others (50%), users’ identities won’t be legally protected (47%), and they will be forced to share even more of their private data, which can be later abused (45%),” NordVPN reported.

Then comes the surprise! Despite all these concerns, 74% said they would join or at least consider joining the metaverse for various reasons, such as experiencing things they can’t in physical reality (41%), communicating with others (40%), escaping their surroundings (28%), or even wanting to be-

come a different person (23%). No wonder organisations are also keen on expanding into the metaverse—where the users and consumers go, they go!

Accessibility. There is also a valid concern about accessibility. Not everyone can afford expensive VR gear. Does that thin down the user base to discouraging levels? Richard Ward of McKinsey explains that between 2D and 3D lies 2.5D, where three-dimensional gaming technology is leveraged, yet the experience isn’t quite truly 3D.

On Ikea’s website, for example, you see images of furniture that you can tilt, rotate, or move around by just swiping with your fingers. Using your camera, you can even fit the object into a real environment to see if it matches with your existing décor. That is 2.5D. In fact, most of the so-called metaverses in India are also in this category. People just experience it on a touchscreen.

This 2.5D logic lowers the barriers to entry, and every company can consider making a no-regrets investment in the metaverse. In the McKinsey podcast, Ward says, “I think that’s really a no-regrets move that allows people to start taking assets they already have, skill sets they already have, and add a little bit of tech, add a little bit of technical capability, and start moving into this 2.5D metaverse environment in a variety of ways.”

“I have conducted ‘tours’ of the metaverse with maybe a thousand people, and every time I strap on one of these headsets and let people experience what’s possible, every single one of them comes away saying they immediately have ideas for how they can bring this into their business. It’s one of those things you need to try, instead of reading about it or watching videos about it. For literally just hundreds of dollars, the metaverse awaits,” he says.

So, what are we waiting for? **EFY**